

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

In Geek Key, we learn about the various types of butterflies in India, in Desire, we list out some wacky and cool gadgets, in Temptation, we review a film, TV show, anime and comic, and in Feature, we see why Indian users seem to prefer OnePlus' OxygenOS over iOS.



How noise affects birbs

Till recently, the affects of noise and light pollution on bird populations were not clearly understood. According to new research the bird populations in North America have declined sharply over the past few decades, because of an increase in noise and light pollution.

<https://dgit.in/nlbrb>

WHAT'S NEW

Is there a universal language?

Say we come in contact with extraterrestrials, how are we going to communicate with them? Humans primarily use scripts and sound for communication, but the extraterrestrials may communicate through other means. The answer then seems to be the language of science, physics and mathematics are believed to be a constant throughout the universe, and this can be a solid foundation on which two mutually alien civilisations can communicate. In 1960, Dr Hans Freudenthal developed a constructed language just for this purpose, known as Lincos. Freudenthal imagined that the language would easily be understood by aliens. The conlang was developed for use in active radio transmis-



sions to aliens. The language was a mostly theoretical exercise, but a broadcast was made in 1999. However, other researchers

point out that even among humans, maths is not as universal as one might believe. For example there are the Piraha people of Brazil, who have only three numbers. They do not even have a concept for a specific number, and if anyone tries to engage with them in terms of pure mathematics, they are going to be in trouble.

<https://astronomy.com/bonus/lingo>

Deepfakes for pop music

Open AI has created the audio version of deepfakes videos, which are essentially songs from popular artists that sound very similar to their works, and even have similar lyrics, but the songs were never written or performed by the artist in question. Even inimical artists such as Frank Sinatra are no match for Open AI's magic Jukebox, that can output songs similar to any artist, apparently on demand. While the technology itself may



be impressive, it opens up a whole bunch of thorny questions. The reactions from long term fans of the artist range from thrill to dismay, and hearing an AI generated rendition of the voice of a long dead artist can

be a deeply unsettling feeling. Then there is the question of legal issues and copyright of the content generated through the use of such technologies. There could be IP issues rising from the unregulated use of the software. For example, if someone wants to hire Liam Neeson as a voice actor, but cannot afford his fees, they can just as well get the same result by using an AI, and save a lot of the cost.

<https://dgit.in/dfmusic>



How music affects you

Apparently listening to music evokes certain physiological reactions, including sensations that can only be described as chills and tingles. Researchers have developed a system that uses AI to measure physical responses of people listening to music, then predict their emotions.

<https://dgit.in/mbrain>



Huracan transports kidney

Italian police used a Lamborghini Huracan to transport a kidney over 300 miles, within just two hours. The vehicle in question has a specially modified refrigerated trunk, and was added to the police fleet for just such a task. The trooper averaged 145 mph over the course of the trip.

<https://dgit.in/hurakid>



Ships contaminate clouds

Exhaust from international shipping lanes emit enough particles to affect clouds in coastal areas, according to a study conducted by the University of Manchester. The clouds in regions where ship emissions are controlled, such the English Channel, were devoid of the pollutants.

<https://dgit.in/shipe>